

society&the arts HERITAGE TRAINS

based on our own experience and that of our writers, editors, members and staff. The trains need to meet stringent standards for service, accommodation, scenery, itinerary, off-train experiences and passenger enjoyment." The chosen 25 trains represented the group's best loved railway journeys, she adds. Considering the steep rates of tickets on these trains, compared to the average tariff of a hotel room, the success of India's state-run royal trains is even more remarkable.

In fact, when the Palace on Wheels was launched in 1984 most critics had dismissed it as a niche product with limited appeal but the itinerary—a week-long journey starting from Delhi and covering the major tourist attractions of Rajasthan with the Taj Mahal thrown in as a bonus—and the royal experience on board has clearly worked. Reconstructed and launched as a broad gauge in 1996, it continues to be the jewel in the luxury rail crown and has sparked a host of imitators like the Heritage on Wheels sometime back in Rajasthan and now the latest, the Golden Chariot, a 19-coach extravaganza which is going to be launched this March. A joint venture of the Karnataka State Tourism Development Corporation, the Union ministry of tourism



and the Railway Ministry, the train's interiors are inspired by the royal palaces of Karnataka.

Like its predecessors, the Golden Chariot will be handled world wide by The Luxury Trains which, with offices strategically located around the world, is the largest consolidator for the Palace on Wheels, Heritage on Wheels and Deccan Odyssey. Like them, the USP of the new train, the first in South India, will be combining the Indian Maharaja experiences with modern comforts and an itinerary that covers major tourist spots. Starting from Bangalore, it will cover Mysore, Kabini wildlife sanctuary, the world heritage site of Hampi and other popular tourist sites before

reaching Goa. At Rs 1,33,610 for the entire trip, inclusive of food and drink, it's hardly a bargain but has generated a great deal of interest from prospective clients in overseas markets.

This is partly to do with the interest generated by India's luxury trains, six at last count, and the positive feedback they have received from users, mostly foreigners (80 per cent) and NRIs. Like the Palace, the Deccan Odyssey's week-long journey starts from a strategically located city, Mumbai, and covers places of major tourist interest in the region including Goa, Ajanta and Ellora and other world heritage sites. The Heritage on Wheels, a collaboration between Rajasthan Tourism Deve-



GOLDEN CHARIOT

ITINERARY: Bangalore-Srirangapatnam-Mysore-Kabini-Hassan-Belur-Halebid-Shravanabelagola-Hampi-Aihole-Patadakal-Padami-Goa-Bangalore

TARIFF:

Rs 1,33,610 per person for a seven-day journey

AMENITIES: 26 AC coaches, two restaurants, a lounge, a gym and a spa car